Arshad, who chaired a joint legislature committee to review the bill in August 2024. The BBMP was created in 2007 to tackle Bengaluru's unwieldy growth by amalgamating peripheral municipal councils and villages in an urban sprawl spanning 786 sq. km into a single corporation.

While Bengaluru's population was about 7.5 million when the BBMP was formed, it has now doubled to 14 million. "That solution no longer worked. The rapid population increase has made it worse," says Arshad. "If you want an organisation that is transparent and closer to the people, it must be decentralised." The newly proposed corporations (the bill allows for up to seven) would be responsible for collecting property taxes and managing the affairs of the region under them, while the Greater Bengaluru Authority will coordinate citywide planning.

While both houses of the state legislature passed the bill in March and it is now awaiting the governor's assent, Opposition parties and civic groups are opposing it, as they are against splitting the BBMP. "Why did the BBMP fail? Because it was not empowered with the correct devolution of functions, funds and functionaries, and citizens were not empowered with proper area sabhas and ward committees," says Kathyayini Chamaraj, executive trustee of the non-profit CIVIC Bangalore, which has petitioned the governor against the GBG Bill, arguing that the state government will take complete charge of planning, governance and funds via the Greater Bengaluru Authority. "The solution is not to take back power from local self-government authorities and give it to the state government. This is a total violation of the intent of the 74th Amendment," she says. Several citizens' groups have now come together under a common platform called the Bengaluru Town Hall (BTH) to oppose the bill and to put forward an alternative vision for the city.

Bengaluru, with its vibrant civic activism, is no stranger to dissent. In fact, in 2016, during his first tenure as CM, Siddaramaiah had to drop a proposal to erect a steel flyover in the heart of the city owing to public uproar over the threat it posed to a large number of trees. This is an episode Shivakumar often recounts in his push for mega road infrastructure projects under the 'Brand Bengaluru' initiative. On March 13, speaking in the legislative council, DKS said that the city was paying the price for not executing the steel flyover project while pointing out that road-widening in the city was no longer feasible given the space constraints and unplanned growth. "There is no alternative, so we have decided to build tunnel roads. The government has approved the first phase and we will be calling for tenders soon," says Shivakumar.

TUNNEL ROADS

Currently, the two key infrastructural projects in the city are the metro rail network and the Bengaluru Suburban Rail Project (BSRP). Construction of 98.5 km of Phase 2 metro rail, besides the existing 73 km operational network, is underway while a new Phase 3 totalling 44.65 km was approved last year.



"IT'S BEEN EIGHT YEARS SINCE THE STEEL FLYOVER PROTESTS, BUT IT IS UNFORTUNATE WE'RE STILL DISCUSSING PROJECTS WE DON'T WANT"

PROF. ASHISH VERMA
Sustainable Transportation Laboratory, IISc



All put together, Bengaluru will have a 220 km metro rail network by 2029. Meanwhile, BSRP, which was slow off the blocks, envisions a 147 km suburban rail network across four corridors.

Also on the cards are two underground tunnel road corridors—a 17 km stretch running north to south from Hebbal to Central Silk Board junction, and a 23 km east-west corridor from Krishnarajapuram to Mysuru Road. While a detailed project report (DPR) has been prepared for the north-south tunnel (cost Rs 17,800 crore), another one is being prepared for the latter. Both projects, with a total cost of Rs 42,000 crore, are being proposed under a Build, Operate, Transfer (BOT) and Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM), with the state government offering a guarantee of Rs 19,000 crore as viability gap funding.

Flagging concerns, P.C. Mohan, the BJP MP from Bengaluru Central, wrote to the BBMP in January saying the north-south tunnel road project conflicts with ongoing initiatives like Metro Phase 3A which also covers the Hebbal-Central Silk Board corridor. "The preparation of the DPR in a mere three months is not only unrealistic but raises serious doubts about its quality and accuracy. Any comprehensive DPR demands a minimum 12-18 months and must include meticulous geotechnical investigations, particularly for a project involving tunneling at a depth of 30 metres," he said. In addition, the DPR also